Stephen Hume: Provincial failures on mining pollution leaving taxpayers on the hook

STEPHEN HUME

More from Stephen Hume (HTTP://VANCOUVERSUN.COM/AUTHOR/STEPHENHUMESUN)

Published on: October 16, 2016 | Last Updated: October 16, 2016 3:02 PM PDT

Mine debris and waste from a tailings dump eroding into the Jordan River, once a stream whose abundant salmon runs sustained the Pacheedaht people who trace their ancestral origins from near here. *STEPHEN HUME / PN*

A pipeline used for the submarine disposal of tailings from a now-abandoned copper mine has contaminated sand, sediments and shellfish at a popular regional park heavily used by surfers, hikers and picnickers.

The abandoned Sunro Mine has recently been identified as a source of copper leaching into the Jordan River, about 70 kilometres west of Victoria. The pollution has been linked to collapsing salmon populations.

University of Victoria graduate student Caleen Kilby found evidence of contamination when sampling sediments at the river's estuary while researching a master's thesis studying the potential for placer metals recovery in 1991, two years before the provincial government declared the site fully remediated.

Tailings from a tidewater discharge pipe used in the 1960s and a submarine pipe added in the 1970s to dispose of waste from the mine two kilometres upstream were identified as the source. Tailings then migrated to contaminate Sandcut Beach, now a regional park. Another report in 2008 by University of Victoria scientist Derek Ellis described the Jordan River tailings disposal system as "an example of how not to design, build and use submarine tailings disposal."

"The Jordan River copper mine was permitted to use very shallow submarine tailings pipeline on a wave-exposed coast," Ellis said. "In hindsight this was obviously a mistake. The pipeline broke several times and although all but the last break was repaired, much of the tailings drifted inshore and contaminated shellfish."

Discovered in 1915, the Sunro Mine passed through numerous

iterations and owners. During peak production it extracted about 1,000 tonnes a day and milled the ore in an underground cavern, refining copper, gold and silver concentrate.

Over the decade before it ceased production in 1974, the mine milled about 1.5 million tonnes of ore. Production was interrupted in 1963 when a blowout resulted in flooding of the underground. At that time a large volume of material was ejected from the mine onto the banks and into the river.

In 1977, the B.C. government investigated the site. Despite the known pipeline breaks, tailings escape and a tailings dump located where it could erode directly into the river, in 1993 the province issued a letter saying "Final reclamation carried out and found satisfactory."

Recent sampling has since found copper concentrations downstream from the abandoned mine that consistently exceed levels prohibited for contaminated sites. In some cases, concentrations are measured at levels 300 per cent higher than the maximum allowable standard.

Last week B.C.'s mines minister, Bill Bennett, told Victoria Times-Colonist reporter Amy Smart he didn't know why a high-risk mine site leaching copper into a salmon-bearing river had been given a clean bill of health.

It wasn't the first time Bennett, who's not running in the next election, has been blind-sided by regulatory failure within his ministry.

When a massive breach at the Mt. Polley mine near Quesnel in 2013 spilled millions of cubic metres of tailings into a critical salmon-producing watershed on the upper Fraser River, a scathing report from Carol Bellringer, the province's auditor-general, concluded that: "The Ministry of Energy and Mines and Ministry of Environment compliance and enforcement activities of the mining sector are inadequate to protect the province from significant environmental risk."

"Almost all of the expectations for a robust compliance and enforcement program were not met," she said.

Now we discover that the high-risk Jordan River site was so far off the province's regulatory radar that it wasn't even listed in the government's report on acid mine drainage.

The province has ordered the mine's present owner to remediate the site citing its so-called "polluter pays" principle. But whether that deserves any more confidence than the failed enforcement identified by the auditor-general remains the question.

Why should it? Mining companies haven't provided government with enough financial security deposits to cover potential reclamation costs should they default. In fact, the auditor-general says the fund has a $1 billion shortfall.

Mining Watch, a national environmental organization, says in its 2016 report there are more than 1,200 mine hazard sites in the province only 76 of which fall under private responsibility for cleanup. It estimates unfunded reclamation liability for taxpayers at more than $3 billion.

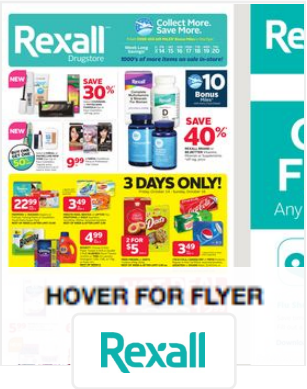
Meanwhile, over the past decade, mining companies in B.C. have earned almost $82 billion in gross revenues.

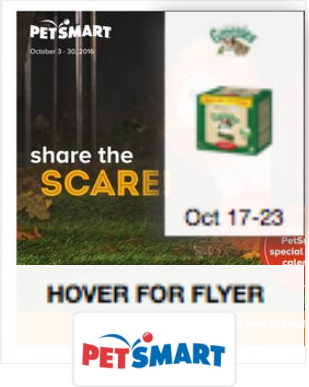
Look, the mining sector is critical to the provincial economy. We need one that's healthy and vigorous. But is it unfair to industry to suggest that British Columbians clearly deserve a better model than one in which shareholders take profits while taxpayers get the environmental bills?

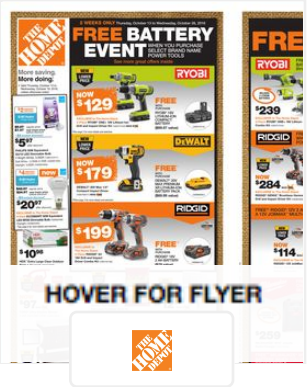
And is it unfair to ask the province who, exactly, is minding the store and why the watchdog is doing such a lousy job?

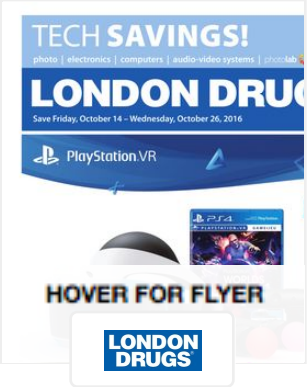
shume@islandnet.com (mailto:shume@islandnet.com)

Vancouver Flyers









Comments

We encourage all readers to share their views on our articles and blog posts. We are committed to maintaining a lively but civil forum for discussion, so we ask you to avoid personal attacks, and please keep your comments relevant and respectful. If you encounter a comment that is abusive, click the "X" in the upper right corner of the comment box to report spam or abuse. We are using Facebook commenting. Visit our FAQ page (http://www.vancouversun.com/news/story.html?id=7195492) for more information.

POSTMEDIA

(HTTP://WWW.POSTMEDIA.COM)

© 2016 Postmedia Network Inc. All rights reserved.

Unauthorized distribution, transmission or republication strictly prohibited.

Powered by WordPress.com VIP (https://vip.wordpress.com/?utm_source=vip_powered_wpcom&utm_medium=web&utm_campaign=VIP%20Footer%20Credit)